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Language, gender and news media: a corpus-assisted critical discourse study of binary gender representations in China Daily

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Abstract

This study gives a corpus-assisted critical discourse study of the binary gender representations in Chinese most influential English-language newspaper *China Daily* (hereinafter CD) during the first two decades of the 21st century. By integrating text mining with FCDS, the research explores the particular ways of binary gender representations in CD synchronically and diachronically and reveals how they are shaped by the competing forces of the state, the market and feminism in China. The findings suggest that while significant progress is evident, such as the shift toward individualized representations of women, increased focus on their rights, health and professional achievements, and broader depictions of diverse life experiences, traditional gender ideologies persist. Media representations continue to emphasize women's marital status, reproductive roles, and domestic responsibilities, reflecting deep-rooted societal norms and highlighting the tension between feminist progress and conventional expectations. The complex patterns in the newspaper's binary gender representations further confirm the dynamic influences of the competing forces of the state, the market, and feminism during the examined period.

Contextualization of this study

For over two millennia, Chinese women were shackled with the constraints of feudal ethics and Confucian doctrines, such as the "three obediences and four virtues" ("sān cóng sì dé") (Su, 2003). For "three obediences", Chinese women were required to obey their fathers before marriage, their husbands after marriage, and their sons if widowed; while the "four virtues" mean fidelity, good manners, physical charm, and excellent needlework (Hong, 1997; Li, 1995; Su, 2003). This oppressive social structure severely restricts the roles and autonomy of Chinese women and links the Chinese feminine virtues with being submissive, filial, and unambitious (Yu, 2019). It was not until the mid-to-late 19th century that these entrenched norms began to be challenged, when China was confronted with the Western power and greatly influenced by its ideas on natural rights and women's rights (Hong, 1997). After that, women's liberation and gender equality served as banners for the Chinese intellectuals to strive for national emancipation and civilization (Li, 1995).

The founding of the People's Republic of China (PRC) in 1949 marked a turning point for the development of gender equality in China. Upon its establishment, the new government implemented various policies to promote gender equality, including the 1950 Marriage Law, which outlawed practices such as child brides and forced

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marriages (Burnett, 2010) and the 1953 Electoral Law, which stipulated the equal right of Chinese women to vote. Meanwhile, the external political mobilization movements such as the land reform ("tǔ dì gǎi gé") and the Great Leap Forward ("dà yuè jìn") also required women to work as equally as men in the public sphere (Croll, 2011). Becoming the vital contributors to the socialist construction of the nation, Chinese women were hailed as "holding up half of the sky" (Luo and Hao, 2007). However, this drive for "absolute" gender egalitarianism may reinforce a "sexless" notion that ignores gender differences (Tang, 2016).

In 1978, China initiated the economic reform. The transformation of a planned to a market-oriented economy has brought about both opportunities and challenges for women (Shu, 2005). On one hand, women had more diverse employment options. On the other hand, they faced increased marginalization, especially during the restructuring of state-owned enterprises (SOEs) in the 1990s. Without the state's intervention and protection, women bore the brunt of urban unemployment (up to 70%), and often relegated to low-paying, unstable jobs with poor working conditions (Keith, 1997). This increasingly severe urban employment condition led to a resurgence of patriarchal gender values, suggesting that women should withdraw from the labour market and return to domestic spheres (Tang, 2016). The rise of consumerism since 1990s further complicated the situation, as it fostered the commercialization of femininity, and often reduced women to their sexualized roles in mass media (Chen, 2016; Evans, 2008; Marchetti, 2009; Wu and Dong, 2019).

In the millennium era, China's economy is featured by a deepened socialist reform and integration into the global community. The progress of gender equality in China can be reflected by women's increasing participation in higher education (Attané, 2012), entrepreneurship (Cooke and Xiao, 2021; Maslak, 2018), and political spheres (Burnett, 2010; Yu et al., 2022). On the other hand, significant conflicts persist in the widening gender salary gap and unemployment rates (Sun and Chen, 2015; Wu and Dong, 2019). Statistics reveal that the average income of urban women constituted approximately 77.5% of that of men in the 1990 while this figure dropped to 70.1 and 67.3 respectively in the years 2000 and 2010 respectively (Attané, 2012). The workplace remains a key site of gender inequality, characterized by persistent pay gaps and career advancement barriers, particularly at executive levels (Sung, 2023; Wang et al., 2024). Meanwhile, traditional cultural values continue to prevail, creating what Evans (2021) describes as a paradox between women's expanding professional opportunities and their enduring pressure to fulfil traditional family roles as daughters, wives and mothers. The rural-urban divide also compounds these challenges (Suen et al., 2022). While urban areas show progress in gender equality, rural women encounter more barriers in the access of education, healthcare opportunities (Song and Ji, 2020). These patterns suggest that while formal barriers to gender equality may have reduced, informal cultural and structural obstacles still persist over the past decades.

Since media play an important role in reproducing gender ideologies and shaping public understanding of gender identities (Fairclough, 1995), it is of great interest and significance to examine how news media in China reflect and reinforce social attitudes towards different genders in the new millennium. Therefore, this study incorporates text mining into feminist critical discourse studies to give a corpus-assisted critical discourse study of the representation and reproduction of the traditional binary gender systems in Chinese most official English-language newspaper, i.e., *China Daily* (CD). It has two primary objectives: (1) to examine the particular ways of binary gender representations in CD; and (2) to explicate to what extent the binary gender representations in the newspaper are shaped by competing forces of the state, the market and the feminist movement.

Previous studies on gender representations in Chinese media

Gender representations in Chinese media have evolved significantly across different historical and socio-economic periods due to broader cultural, political and market transformations. These shifts have shown the mixed influences of socialist ideals, market demands and global trends (Chen, 2009).

During the Maoist era, representations of women in Chinese media were closely related to the Chinese government's efforts to promote gender equality as part of the broader socialist agenda (Croll, 2011). Women were usually represented as gender-neutral or even masculine: they were often depicted in plain working clothes and engaged in

agricultural, industrial, or military work (Luo and Hao, 2007). These representations underlined women's contributions to labour and social construction, and aligned with the Marxist ideology, which linked women's emancipation to proletarian liberation. While these representations avoided traditional gender stereotypes, they often obscured the existing gender hierarchy within the male-dominated labour force (Acker, 1999). In contrast, men were often represented as soldiers, muscular workers and peasants, embodying physical strength, courage, and martial vigour (Hird, 2019; Hu, 2018). They reflected on the state's emphasis on "wǔ" masculinity (martial masculinity).

In the post-Mao period, women representations in Chinese media shifted dramatically. As a result of growing marketization, feminine imagery, which used to be suppressed during the Maoist era (Chen, 2016; Evans, 1997), became increasingly prevalent, particularly in advertising, where women were often objectified and depicted through beauty and sexuality (Wallis, 2006). This commercialization of femininity was seen as a response to the "degendered" and ascetic culture of the Maoist era. At the same time, representations of independent, educated, and career-oriented women became more visible in the mainstream media (Nie and Wang, 2019). However, despite these changes, women remain underrepresented and misrepresented in media discourse. Feminist issues are often represented in a fragmented way or receive limited coverage (Chen, 2009). Some more challenging issues, such as prostitution and LGBTQ+ rights, are often marginalized (Wang and Ma, 2021). Besides, unmarried women, despite their education and professional success, are often represented as problematic, thus reflecting persistent social biases towards them (Feldshuh, 2018; Yu, 2019).

Representations of men in Chinese media have also undergone significant changes. In the contemporary period, the emphasis on "wǔ" masculinity has gradually given way to the more diverse and globalized representations of men (Hu, 2018; Louie, 2002). This can be seen from the concept of the "metrosexual," localized in China as "bái lǐng lì nán" ("white-collar beautiful man"), emphasizes androgynous appearances, narcissistic personalities, and fashionable lifestyles (Song and Hird, 2014). This softer image aligns with the "wén" (civil/mental) aspect of traditional Chinese masculinity (Louie, 2012). Additionally, alternative masculinities have emerged, challenging hegemonic norms. For example, the "niáng pào" ("sissy pants") phenomenon and the "xiǎo xiān ròu" ("little fresh meat") trend depict young male celebrities as aesthetic and consumable objects, reflecting the commodification of male bodies and a departure from traditional ideals of masculinity (Song, 2022; Yu et al., 2025).

Despite these evolving representations, feminist perspectives in Chinese media still face significant challenges. The state's strong influence over media, combined with market-oriented reforms since the 1990s, has limited the ability of feminist viewpoints to gain traction. Media discourse still prefers to filter feminist topics, focused on stated-aligned issues while marginalizing more contentious social agendas. The mixed influences of state control, market demands, and feminist aspirations continues to create a complex environment that prevents the representation of feminist movements and broader gender equality (Chen, 2009). However, in view of the unique role of CD in China's media system and its special function of communicating the voices of the Chinese government to the external world and cultivating a positive image for the Chinese government, there is still little information about to what extent its gender representations are shaped by the competing forces of the state, the market and feminism.

Corpus-assisted critical discourse studies

This study adopts a corpus-assisted critical discourse study (CACDS) approach by incorporating corpus linguistic methods into feminist critical discourse studies (FCDS). A CACDS approach underlines the "synergy" or balanced combination of the methods and theories of critical discourse studies and corpus linguistics to give a close examination of language use in a large sample of texts (Baker, 2006; Baker et al., 2008; Baker et al., 2013; Mautner, 2009).

FCDS advocates a political stance to examine the asymmetric power structure underlying the gendered discourses with an attempt to achieve emancipation (Lazar, 2005). With a focus on social justice and transformation, this approach is mainly concerned with "critiquing discourses which sustain a patriarchal social order" that privileges men while disadvantages women (Lazar, 2007, p. 145). Different from gender studies employing CDA, FCDS is "fundamentally driven by developments in critical feminist theory and practice" (Lazar, 2014, p.182). Further, FCDS is not merely deconstructing texts and talks as an academic practice, but is driven by an enactment of social changes,

with a position of knowing that the examined issues could have material impact for groups of women and men in specific communities and contexts (Lazar, 2014).

Viewing discourse as a "site of struggles" for the (re)production and contestation of gendered ideologies and assumptions (Lehtonen, 2007, p. 5), FCDS aims "to show up the complex, subtle, and sometimes not so subtle, ways in which frequently taken-for-granted gendered assumptions and hegemonic power relations are discursively produced, sustained, negotiated, and challenged in different contexts and communities" (Lazar, 2007, p. 142). This involves questioning the status quo and challenging the discursive practices that marginalize or subordinate people based on gender. By exposing and understanding how language can enforce or challenge gender biases, scholars aim to promote more equitable social practices and policies (Lazar, 2007, 2014). The focus is not on developing a grand theory of gender but rather on investigating how gender is constructed across diverse texts—from media articles and political speeches to legal documents, everyday conversations, and social media content—to understand how gender ideologies are articulated and negotiated across different genres and communicative contexts (Sunderland and Litosseliti, 2002).

Previous studies have demonstrated that frequent lexical patterns can reveal the interactions among language, society, and culture (Jevrić, 2017). However, the combination of corpus linguistics and gender representations as a field of study has only gained significant attention in recent years (Baker, 2014a). Earlier research primarily focused on examining gender terms in corpora, particularly in relation to asymmetry and sexism (Holmes and Sigley, 2002; Pearce, 2008; Sigley and Holmes, 2002). For instance, Sigley and Holmes (2002)'s analysis reveals that references to *women* doubled between the 1960s and 1990s, while references to *woman* remains less frequent than singular *man* (though improving from 1:5 to 1:2 ratio). Their study confirms persistent masculine bias with MAN occurring 1.5 times more frequently than WOMAN. It also reveals distinct grammatical patterns: singular form dominates for MAN versus plural form for WOMAN. While these approaches are useful for understanding how frequently men and women are talked and written about, investigating gender representations solely through frequency counts may provide an indicative rather than an accurate depiction of these representations (Pearce, 2008).

To address this limitation, some studies have turned to collocation analysis, another key concept in corpus linguistics (Caldas-Coulthard and Moon, 2010; Pearce, 2008; Taylor, 2013). Collocation refers to frequent co-occurrence of certain words in close proximity (Baker, 2006). Pearce (2008) conducted a collocation analysis on BNC through Sketch Engine, revealing distinct verb collocation patterns between WOMAN and MAN. The former appears as the object of sexual violence and coercion verbs, while the latter is found associated with non-sexual violence and seduction verbs. Further, MAN is associated with competitiveness, rationality, aggression, and dominance, while WOMAN is with emotional intemperance, physical weakness, and subordination. The study of Caldas-Coulthard and Moon (2010) demonstrates that newspaper coverage modifies women through physical appearance (*beautiful*, *pretty*) and men through importance (*key*, *big*, and *main*). Men are more frequently categorized in terms of age, status, and personality, whereas women are classified by physical appearance.

Previous corpus-assisted critical discourse studies examining gender representation from a diachronic perspective reveal complex patterns of linguistic evolution (Baker, 2008, 2010, 2014b). Baker (2008)'s analysis of BNC texts across three periods (1960-1974, 1975-1984, 1985-1993) demonstrates decreased usage of explicitly sexist terms (*mankind*, *ladylike*) and increased adoption of gender-neutral language (*him* or *her*, *chairperson*). However, certain gendered terms (*early man*, *male nurse/prostitute*) show increased frequency, suggesting the persistence of gender biases. Baker (2010)'s expanded study across four time periods (1931, 1961, 1991, 2006) reveals declining frequency of male-specific terms, particularly pronouns and honorifics. However, the collocation analysis of *man*/*woman* indicates enduring gender stereotypes, especially in the absence of success-related adjectives with *woman*. These patterns suggest a decrease in explicit gender bias in language, but subtle forms of linguistic gender discrimination continue to persist in contemporary English usage.

Nevertheless, most of these studies have been conducted in American and European contexts, with fewer studies conducted in other contexts (Ahmed, 2019). There is little information about the particular ways of gender representations in the Chinese context, CD in particular. Besides, previous studies used to rely on the traditional corpus linguistic methods, such as frequencies and collocates, failing to take advantage of recent development in

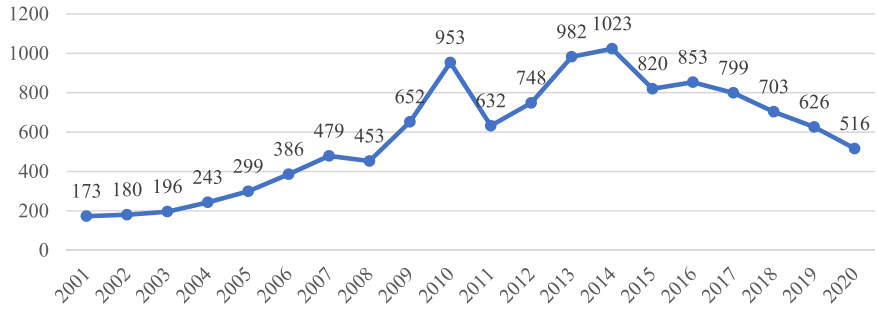


Fig. 1 The number of news texts collected for each year.

computational linguistics and text mining (Liu, 2024). This study contributes to this area of studies by incorporating text mining into corpus-assisted studies of gender representations in different texts.

Data and methodology

Data collection and corpus building

This study focuses on the largest official English-language newspaper *China Daily* (CD) (Liu, 2014; Wang and Ma, 2021). Founded in 1981, CD functions as a significant platform for conveying Chinese perspectives to international audiences, offering comprehensive coverage of domestic and global affairs. The newspaper serves as a crucial medium for cross-cultural communication and acts as a primary English-language information source about China for international readers (Liu and Ma, 2022). As the oldest and also the most influential official English-language newspaper in China, CD represents an authoritative source for analyzing the communication of official voices towards certain issues to global readers in the international arena.

The data for this study was collected through the electronic database *Factiva* with a timespan from January 1, 2001 to December 31, 2020. This timeframe was selected as it marks a transformative era in China's socio-economic development, characterized by rapid globalization and increased international influence. While these changes are well-documented, little is known about whether they have influenced gender representations in China's global communication. Besides, a twenty-year period allows for the analysis of both synchronic and diachronic changes. This dual perspective provides a comprehensive understanding of how gender representations have shifted during this critical period of change.

News articles were first retrieved by using the search terms typically for binary gender representations, i.e., WOMAN, MAN, MALE, and FEMALE, with a minimum frequency threshold of two occurrences per article. This frequency criterion was set to generate a manageable dataset while ensuring content relevance. The resulting articles were then filtered through a dual-stage approach combining automated retrieval with manual selection. The first stage used Factiva's built-in functions to remove duplication and narrow down articles that were mentioned in China only. Then the articles were filtered manually to ensure they were focused on Chinese subjects. Finally, the articles were organized chronologically into 20 annual sub-corpora for systematic analysis.

In total, 11,716 texts were identified. Figure 1 illustrates the number of articles collected each year. Overall, the number of articles increases from 2001 to 2014, followed by a gradual decline (see Fig. 1). Notably, the peaks around 2010 and 2014 correspond to some major social and political contexts: the 2010 Shanghai World Expo, the rise of the "*shengnü*" ("leftover women") debate (Fincher, 2014; Yu, 2019), the launch of the *Outline for Women's Development in China (2011–2020)* in 2011 (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 2011), and the release of the *Anti-Domestic Violence Law* draft in 2014 (National People's Congress of the People's Republic of China, 2014). These contextual factors suggest that fluctuations in media reports were closely linked to broader social and political developments. The entire corpus comprises 8,238,904 tokens. For the convenience of diachronic comparison, the 20

Table 1 Detailed information for each 5-year sub-corpus.

Periods	Sub-corpora	Texts	Tokens
Period 1 (P1)	2001–2005	1091	780,525
Period 2 (P2)	2006–2010	2923	1,938,403
Period 3 (P3)	2011–2015	4205	3,083,224
Period 4 (P4)	2016–2020	3497	2,436,752

corpora were further classified into four sub-corpora, each covering a span of 5 years. Table 1 provides detailed information about the four sub-corpora.

Analytic methods and procedure

This study begins by examining the frequencies of four representative terms for binary gender representations (MAN, WOMAN, MALE, and FEMALE) over a 20-year period to reveal their distribution patterns. Given the higher frequency of MAN and WOMAN in the corpus, the analysis extends to their singular and plural forms (*man*/*men*, *woman*/*women*) to examine usage preferences across the four sub-corpora.

The corpora are then analysed through KH Coder, which is a free text-mining tool developed for quantitative content analysis (Liu et al., 2022). It integrates Stanford POS Tagger for word extraction, R for statistical analysis, and MySQL for data organization (Higuchi, 2016). KH Coder offers multiple analytical functions, including frequency lists, keyword-in-context concordance, word association, correspondence analysis, and co-occurrence network analysis (Higuchi, 2016, 2017; Liu, 2024). With coding rules for the terms MAN and WOMAN, the analysis begins with word association mappings, which are further visualized into co-occurring networks in various colour themes (Liu, 2024). The top 100 strongly co-occurring words for each term are focused by this study.

The analysis then examines the top 200 co-occurring adjectives for MAN and WOMAN. Unlike traditional collocate analysis which examines fixed token windows, this word association analysis identifies words with strong sentence-level co-occurrence (Higuchi, 2016, 2017). Using Loglikelihood (LL) as the statistical measure, these adjectives are categorized semantically (e.g., Age, Crimes/Violence, Marital status, Provenance). Our initial categorization schema followed the broad categories "Functionalization" "Identification" and "Appraisement" from van Leeuwen's inventory (van Leeuwen, 2008), which include sub-dimensions such as occupation, age, class, wealth, ethnicity, and sexual orientation, which can commonly capture social actor descriptors. Then we refined this schema by extracting the top 200 adjectives co-occurring with MAN or WOMAN and iteratively grouping them. Categories were refined and, where necessary, split or added to reflect the empirical distribution of the adjectives. The actual categorization was based on semantic function in concordance, not merely on isolated lemmas. Ambiguous items were resolved by close readings of the concordance lines. However, in order to track whether there are explicit signs of improvement as a result of social development, a diachronic analysis of these semantic categories across four periods was further performed to complement the findings.

The findings from these analyses are compared with previous studies in the American and European contexts to identify convergences and divergences in gender representations (Baker, 2014b; Caldas-Coulthard and Moon, 2010; Pearce, 2008). The results are interpreted through the lens of gender ideology production and reproduction, with particular attention to stereotyping patterns (Lazar, 2007). The analysis contextualizes these findings within China's evolving socio-political landscape, examining how the interplay of state influence, market forces, and feminist movements shapes gender representations in Chinese news media (Chen, 2009). This study aims to provide novel insights into gender portrayal patterns in CD. Figure 2 shows the analytic procedure.

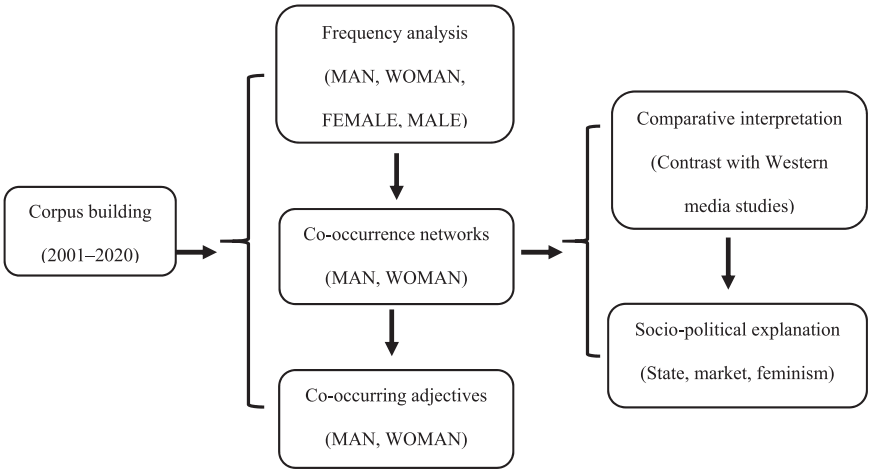


Fig. 2 Visualizing the analytic procedure.

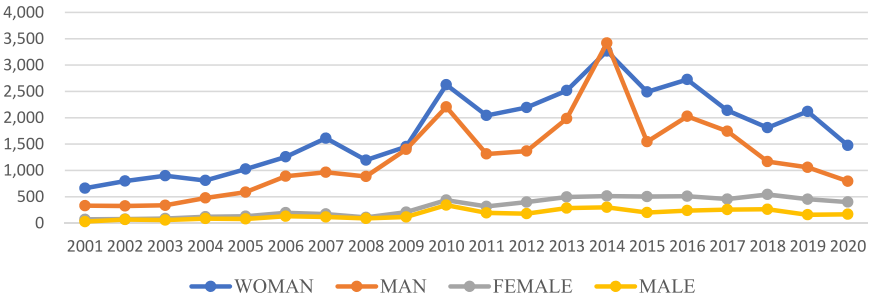


Fig. 3 Raw frequencies of four gender terms from 2001 to 2020.

Findings

Analysis of the distribution of gender terms over 20 years

Figure 3 shows the raw frequencies of the terms MAN, WOMAN, MALE, and FEMALE over the past 20 years. MAN and WOMAN are used much more frequently than MALE and FEMALE. In contrast, WOMAN tends to be used more frequently than MAN, while FEMALE tends to be used more frequently than MALE. Overall, MAN and WOMAN exhibit similar trends over the 20 years: both show a rising trend before 2014 and a declining trend afterward. This pattern is also consistent with the trend in the number of articles published each year.

Standardized frequency analysis over the 20-year period also confirms the predominance of WOMAN and MAN over FEMALE and MALE terms (Fig. 4). However, distinct patterns are found diachronically: WOMAN exhibits a gradual decline until 2013, followed by a brief increase during 2014–2016, before declining again. MAN displays an opposing pattern, showing modest growth until 2014, followed by a downward trajectory thereafter.

While these frequency shifts cannot, in themselves, serve as direct measures of social change, they are consistent with broader socio-political development during the examined period. For example, Chen and He (2020) documented China's declining performance in gender equality measures, noting that while China's gender inequality score in 2009 exceeded the 112-country average by 1.11 times, it had regressed to average levels by 2015. Evans (2021) attributes this shift to the resurgence of Confucian values, which has influenced official discourse, including that of the Women's Federation. The shifting gender values emphasize traditional feminine roles in domestic sphere while diminishing the prominence of gender equality in party-state rhetoric.

Figure 5 demonstrates the standardized frequency distributions of *woman*, *women*, *man*, and *men* throughout the study period. It is found that *women* in plural form significantly outnumbers its singular form, while *man* appears

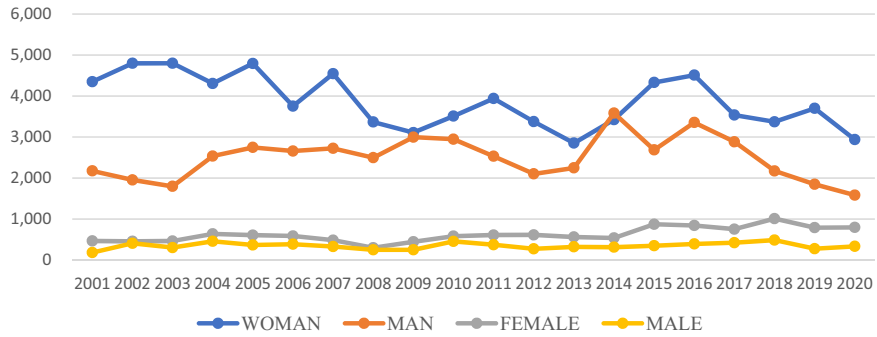


Fig. 4 Standardized frequencies of four gender terms from 2001 to 2020.

more frequently than *men*. This pattern, where women are referenced collectively while men individually, aligns with previous research findings in other contexts (Holmes and Sigley, 2002; Pearce, 2008).

From a diachronic perspective, frequency of *men* declines in usage, while *man* increased until 2014 before decreasing. *Women* exhibited a decline before 2014 followed by an increase, while *woman* maintained relative stability with notable fluctuations during 2014–2016. Recent trends show declining usage of plural forms (*men*, *women*) accompanied by increasing use of singular forms (*man*, *woman*), suggesting a shift toward more individualized representation. However, the persistent underrepresentation of individual women compared to men in the corpus indicates continuing gender inequality in media coverage (Holmes and Sigley, 2002).

The analysis suggests that 2014 represents a turning point in China's gender representations. This co-occurred with subsequent setback in China's feminist movement in 2015 and the concurrent reforms of mass organizations, particularly the All-China Women's Federation. These changes resulted in heightened political control and increased demands for political loyalty (Liu et al., 2015; Zhou, 2019).

Nevertheless, frequencies should not be taken at face value but interpreted in relation to societal knowledge, supported by concordance analysis of how specific words are used in context within a corpus (Baker, 2006, 2014b). The following sections give a close analysis of the use of MAN and WOMAN in the corpus to reveal both synchronic and diachronic patterns.

Co-occurrence networks of MAN and WOMAN

The tokens associated with MAN can be categorized into nine distinct themes, as illustrated in Fig. 6. **Theme 1** centres on law enforcement activities, characterized by terms such as *police*, *detain*, *catch*, *steal*, *accuse*, *suspicion*, *arrest*, *suspect*, and *POLICE*, primarily focusing on the detention and arrest of thieves and robbers. Media coverage emerges in two related themes (**Themes 2** and **7**), evidenced by terms like *news*, *reports*, *Chongqing*, *Huashang*, *Daily*, and *Metropolis*. **Theme 3** emphasizes male-perpetrated violent crimes, featuring words such as *beat*, *death*, *kill*, *wife*, *stab*, *attack*, and *injure*, while **Theme 4** addresses marriage dynamics between young men and women, employing terms like *man*, *woman*, *young*, and *marry*. **Theme 5** concentrates on legal consequences, utilizing vocabulary such as *sentence*, *prison*, *jail*, *court*, *fine*, and *yuan*, complemented by **Theme 6**'s focus on murder convictions (*convict*, *murder*). The remaining themes addresses homosexuality (*gay*, *sex*) (**Theme 8**) and vehicle operation (*drive*, *car*) (**Theme 9**). Overall, the network constructs a complex portrait of man-related discourse that spans law enforcement, social relationships, criminal behaviour, and daily activities.

Figure 7 shows six major themes associated with WOMAN. **Theme 1** centres on matrimonial relationships, employing terms like *man*, *woman*, *marry*, and *marriage*. **Theme 2** focuses on institutional support for women's issues, highlighting organizations such as the All-China Women's Federation and the China Foundation for Human Rights Development, characterized by terms including *WOMEN*, *FEDERATION*, *CHINA*, *DEVELOPMENT*, *FOUNDATION*, *children*, *All-China*, and *rural*. Women's rights protection emerges as **Theme 3**, particularly concerning reproductive rights and workplace safety, evidenced by words such as *rights*, *protect*, *protection*,

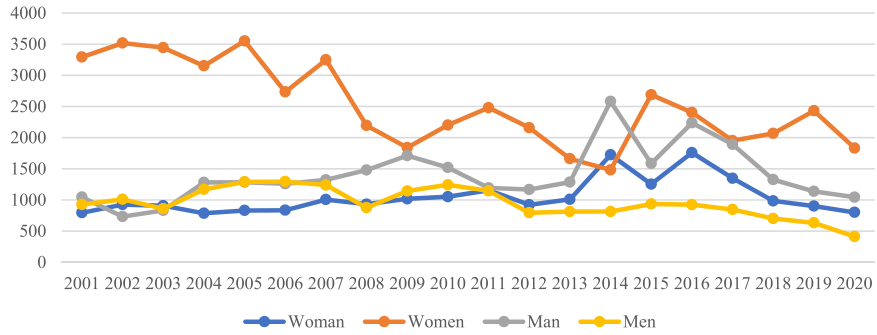


Fig. 5 Standardized frequencies of *woman*, *women*, *man*, and *men* from 2001 to 2020.

reproductive, *single*, *married*, *interests*, *Rights*, *sexual*, *harassment*, and *workplace*. **Theme 4** addresses gender equality and anti-discrimination efforts, featuring terms like *gender*, *discrimination*, *elimination*, *employment*, *empowerment*, *social*, *status*, *role*, and *society*. **Theme 5** revolves around reproduction and maternity, incorporating words such as *birth*, *child*, *pregnant*, *pregnancy*, *childbirth*, *elderly*, *give*, and *childbearing*. **Theme 6** concerns women's health issues, specifically focusing on cervical and breast cancer, as indicated by the terms *cervical*, *breast*, and *cancer*. This thematic distribution reflects a discourse that encompasses women's social roles, institutional support, rights protection, equality initiatives, reproductive health, and medical concerns.

Therefore, the above analysis reveals significant gender-based representational patterns. The portrayal of men predominantly focuses on **criminality** and **violence**, which foregrounds their agency and visibility in public discourse, but also associates them with moral condemnation. Comparatively, women are frequently depicted as requiring protection, which reinforces the perceptions of **vulnerability**. This aligns with Pearce (2008)'s findings on gendered media representation patterns.

Gender representations also vary in grammatical choices. MAN frequently appears with active verbs denoting violence or criminal behaviour (*murder*, *attack*, *kill*, *beat*, *drive*, *steal*), while discourse around WOMAN often employs nominalization to background negative actions (*domestic violence*, *sexual harassment*, *discrimination*). Unlike previous studies in the American and European contexts, Chinese media coverage rarely positions WOMAN as a direct object of sexual violence (Pearce, 2008), instead emphasizing governmental protection and control of male perpetrators.

This representational asymmetry reflects and reinforces traditional power dynamics. While men are portrayed through actions demonstrating **strength** and **aggression**, women appear primarily as recipients of others' actions, particularly in contexts of **protection** or **victimization**. The media thus perpetuates rather than challenges conventional gender hierarchies, depicting men in positions of power (albeit often negative) while constructing women as emotionally oriented and vulnerable.

Overall analysis of strong co-occurring adjectives of MAN and WOMAN

Co-occurring adjectives reveal patterns in how society characterizes men and women and what qualities receive emphasis. While Baker (2010) found similar basic descriptors (age, size, marital status) used for both MAN and WOMAN, our analysis of the top 200 co-occurring adjectives shows clear differences in how each gender is described. These descriptors fall into 18 distinct categories (see Table 2 for the definitions and examples for these categories and Table 3 for exact collocates of each category).

As Fig. 8 shows, age-related terms (*young*, *old, elderly*, *older*, *younger*, *middle-aged*) dominate the adjectives for both genders, though they appear more frequently with MAN (196,051 occurrences) than WOMAN (126,722). The descriptions of men show greater age specificity across all life stages, while women's age descriptions are less precise, particularly in middle age. Men are described across a broader age spectrum when specific numbers are used (Caldas-Coulthard and Moon, 2010). This disparity reflects media tendencies to focus more on middle-aged men than women, while emphasizing youth as a key theme in coverage of both genders (Ye et al., 2012).

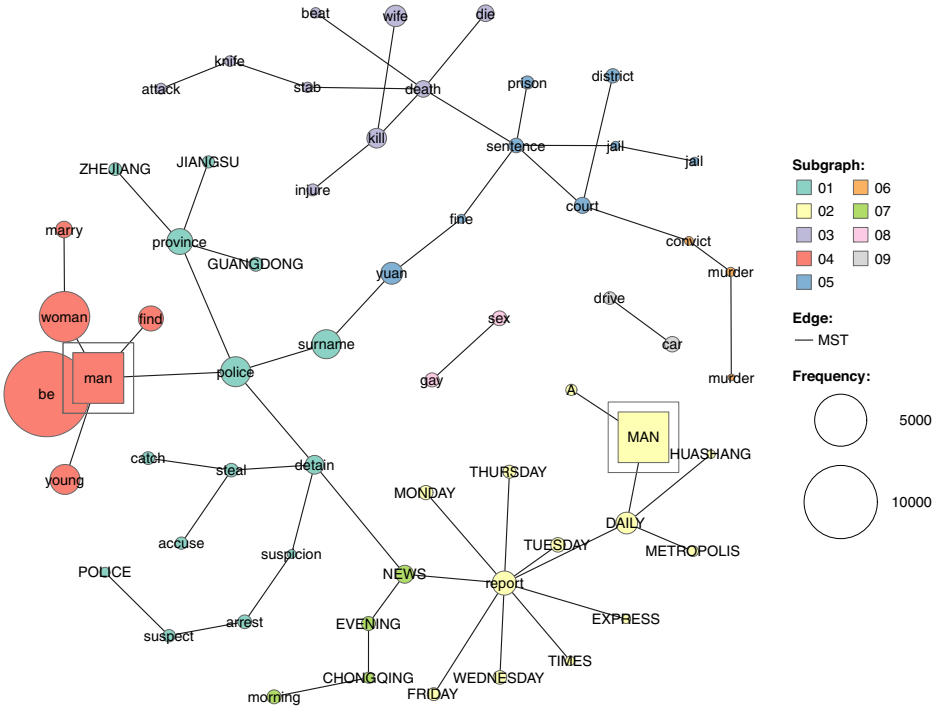


Fig. 6 Strong co-occurring words of MAN.

The analysis of adjective preferences also indicates distinct patterns for MAN and WOMAN, though with some overlap. MAN most frequently co-occurs with adjectives related to Crimes/Violence (35,725), Wealth/Status (26,531), Marital Relation (18,694), Sexual Orientation (18,607), Appearance (17,293), Behaviour (16,330), and Provenance (11,777). WOMAN shows higher frequencies in categories including Wealth/Status (100,477), Provenance (70,279), Reproduction (48,931), Crimes/Violence (43,244), Marital Relation (32,236), Evaluative (18,916), Behaviour (18,094), Intellect (14,932), Appearance (14,354), and Attractiveness (14,324). In total, five categories are shared frequently by both terms, including Wealth/Status, Crimes/Violence, Marital Relation, Behaviour, and Appearance.

Crimes/Violence and **Marital Relation** emerge as significant descriptive categories for both genders, but with distinct patterns. In crime-related descriptions, men are typically described as perpetrators (*dead*, *sexual*, *injured*, *guilty*, *suspect*, *intentional*), while women are portrayed as victims (*domestic*, *sexual*, *legal*, *physical*, *abused*). Marital relation descriptors show more overlap, with both genders described as *single*, *married*, *leftover*, and *unmarried*. However, women receive additional labels like *left-behind*, *marital*, and *extramarital*. These terms, particularly *leftover*, reflect China's changing marriage patterns, though the social stigma of being unmarried weighs more heavily on women, whose societal worth remains closely tied to marital status. Examples are as follows:

1) A ***man*** killed five people and ***injured*** nine others on Sunday in a shopping centre in Shanshan County, Northwest China's Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region, before jumping to his death off a building. (CD, 22/02/2005)
2) Though popular among the Web watching public, most hosting sites have voluntarily removed the disturbing 2 min and 45 s video, which shows the young ***woman*** holding her belly while being kicked, punched and verbally ***abused***. (CD, 03/02/2010)
3) The survey paints a picture of the typical daily routine of a ***married woman*** involving rushing to work in the morning after seeing her husband and child off, and rushing back from work in the evening to take care of the family. (CD, 11/03/2003)
4) A recent survey on the sexual habits and reproductive health of Guangdong's migrant laborers showed that up to 36 percent of ***married men*** have experienced severe sexual repression. (CD, 30/01/2010)

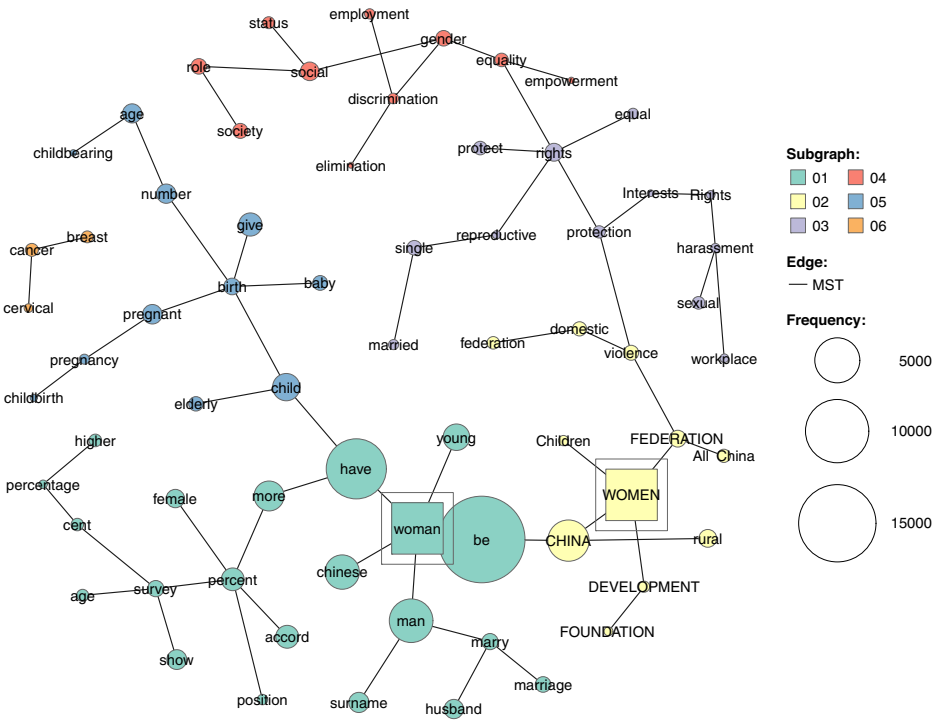


Fig. 7 Strong co-occurring words of WOMAN.

5) While the "leftover women" phenomenon has been perhaps overstated, the rarely discussed reality of the "missing women" means there are actually far more "***leftover men***" - many of whom would be considered catches. (CD, 09/02/2014)
6) Recently, the degrading term of "sheng nu", which literally means "***leftover women***", has been created to refer to the "3S women" as though there were something morally wrong with them. (CD, 09/12/2008)

Wealth/Status descriptors reveal stark gender contrasts. Men are predominantly characterized by markers of success (*rich*, *successful*, *wealthy*, *self-made*) and specific rankings of wealth (*richest*, *second-richest*, *third-richest*). While some women are described with positive status markers (*important*, *senior*, *successful*, *powerful*, *wealthy*), they are more frequently portrayed through indicators of disadvantage (*poor*, *impoverished*, *laid-off*, *poverty-stricken*, *unemployed*, *disadvantaged*, *weaker*, *subordinate*). These patterns reflect and reinforce social disparities in economic and social status between genders. Examples are as follows:

7) Women who are less educated have a stronger desire to marry ***rich men*** and rely on their husbands, she added. (CD, 11/09/2007)
8) Some people called for reduction in taxes on sanitary products to ease the financial burden on women, while others suggested that the government provide them for free to ***poor women***. (CD, 01/09/2020)
9) The state has established a new-model social relief system, increasing efforts to protect ***impoverished women***. (CD, 23/09/2015)

Behaviour descriptors show distinct gendered patterns. Men's characterizations are predominantly positive (*innocent*, *capable*, *ambitious*, *gentle*, *humble*, *upright*, *brave*), with only a few negative terms (*unable*, *stingy*). Gender-specific traits like *feminine*, *masculine*, *effeminate*, and *manly* appear frequently. Women's behavioural descriptions are more mixed: while some emphasize empowerment (*strong*, *independent*, *confident*, *capable*, *ambitious*), others reflect traditional gender expectations and social constraints (*conservative*, *obedient*, *chaste*, *subservient*). The inclusion of terms like *unfaithful* for women suggests ongoing social scrutiny of female behaviour and adherence to traditional roles, as in the following:

10) "When a bright and pretty woman enters the man's life and fulfils his emotional needs, many wives don't know how to protect their marriages beyond useless crying and humiliating begging." Zheng says. But more wives

Table 2 Semantic categories of MAN and WOMAN.

Categories	Definitions	Examples
Age	Refers to life stage or chronological age	*young, old*
Wealth/Status	Indicates economic position, social standing, or prestige	*rich, equal, successful*
Provenance	Refers to geographical origin, place of residence, or locality	*local, rural, urban*
Reproduction	Describes biological or reproductive roles and capacities	*biological, reproductive, maternal*
Crimes/Violence	Associates individuals with crime, violence, or legal matters	*domestic, sexual, legal*
Marital Relation	Indicates marital or relational status	*single, married, leftover*
Evaluative	Expresses value judgments, quality, or appraisal not tied to a specific domain	*right, better, outstanding*
Behaviour	Describes habitual conduct, personality, or manner of acting	*strong, independent, wild*
Intellect	Denotes mental capacity, knowledge, or educational attainment	*wise, well-educated*
Appearance	Refers to observable, physical, or visible traits, without evaluative judgment	*black, white, nude*
Attractiveness	Expresses evaluations of sexual or romantic desirability or beauty	*handsome, attractive*
Occupation	Relates to professional role, position, or work identity.	*professional, managerial*
Emotion	Denotes emotional states, affective dispositions, or moods	*angry, shy, emotional*
Patriarchy/Tradition	Reflects hierarchical gender relations, traditional norms, or patriarchal ideologies	*superior, inferior, male-dominated*
Size	Refers to physical size, build, or body shape	*tall, slender, sturdy*
Sexual Orientation	Denotes sexual identity or orientation	*gay, homosexual, bisexual*
Lifestyle	Characterizes habitual lifestyle choices, behaviours, or vices	*drunk, drunken*
HIV	Specifies HIV status or related health condition	*HIV-positive*

seem to be having affairs, too. ***Unfaithful women*** account for about 20% or 30% of the cases Zheng handles, he says. (CD, 11/01/2010)

Appearance adjectives also reveal evident gendered patterns in Chinese media discourse. MAN co-occurs with a broad range of descriptors spanning physical characteristics (*blind*, *muscular*, *paralyzed*, *bald*, *hairy*, *wrinkled*, *bearded*, *bespectacled*, *grey-haired*), attire (*well-dressed*, *uniformed*, *shirtless*, *half-naked*, *tattered*), and racial markers (*black*, *white*). In contrast, WOMAN's co-occurring adjectives focus predominantly on fashion and clothing choices (*modern*, *fashionable*, *clad*, *well-dressed*, *figure-hugging*), with fewer references to physical attributes. Both genders share descriptors like *naked* and *nude*, reflecting China's increasing acceptance of Western advertising norms since the 1980s. Examples are as follows:

11) Most portal sites in China look like a high school boy's fantasy room, with half ***naked women*** in all kinds of postures. I guess that's the reason several of the most heavily trafficked websites in China were cited for "low and vulgar practices" and became a target for a Net nanny campaign. (CD, 09/01/2009)
12) The odd thing is, given the emphasis on harmonious Internet content in China, that they are available. I am denied access to sites with ***naked ladies or men***, but can access those showing semi-clothed women torturing bunnies to death. (CD, 02/12/2010)
13) Xiao Yu, who admitted to going on a two-week diet before her shoot as she did not want to see her "muffin top" years later, said she feels ***nude*** pictures are about ***women*** being outgoing and confident, and have nothing to do with being disrespectful. (CD, 10/12/2010)

Nudity in advertising has become more prevalent, particularly with female models, indicating China's shift toward Western marketing aesthetics in its consumer-oriented society (Ye et al., 2012). However, the broader range of physical descriptors for MAN, compared to the fashion-focused descriptors for WOMAN, presents an interesting contrast to previous research. While Jevrić (2017) suggests physical attractiveness is more semantically relevant for women, Chinese media appears to maintain a more comprehensive physical description of men while focusing on

Table 3 Strong co-occurring adjectives of MAN and WOMAN.

Categories	MAN	WOMAN
Age	*young, old, elderly, middle-aged, older, younger, 30-year-old, 24-year-old, 21-year-old, 26-year-old, 27-year-old, 25-year-old, 20-year-old, 22-year-old, 29-year-old, 28-year-old, 50-year-old, 23-year-old, 40-year-old, 34-year-old, teenage, 70-year-old, 32-year-old, 39-year-old, 33-year-old, 18-year-old, 60-year-old, 19-year-old, 44-year-old, 31-year-old, 38-year-old, 62-year-old, 35-year-old, 53-year-old, 46-year-old, 80-year-old, 52-year-old, 48-year-old, 41-year-old, 36-year-old, 58-year-old, 72-year-old, 57-year-old, 47-year-old, 49-year-old, 45-year-old, 43-year-old, 56-year-old, 66-year-old, 54-year-old, 65-year-old, 64-year-old, 61-year-old, 76-year-old, 90-year-old, 78-year-old, 74-year-old, 68-year-old, 73-year-old, 71-year-old, middle-age, 69-year-old, 83-year-old, 89-year-old, 60-something, post-95, marriageable*	*young, old, elderly, older, middle-aged, younger, 26-year-old, 24-year-old, 25-year-old, 20-year-old, 27-year-old, 28-year-old, 30-year-old, 23-year-old, 19-year-old, 21-year-old, 22-year-old, 35-year-old, 32-year-old, 60-year-old, 18-year-old, 34-year-old, 70-year-old, 80-year-old, 46-year-old, 48-year-old, 78-year-old, 65-year-old, 59-year-old, 30-something, 85-year-old, 90-year-old, 82-year-old, 83-year-old, marriageable*
Wealth/status	*rich, equal, successful, richest, wealthy, homeless, unemployed, self-made, wealthiest, second-richest, third-richest*	*social, economic, important, equal, senior, financial, poor, political, successful, low, powerful, wealthy, impoverished, laid-off, poverty-stricken, unemployed, richest, disadvantaged, self-made, weaker, decision-making, wealthiest, subordinate, start-up*
Provenance	*autonomous, Henan, downtown*	*local, rural, urban, migrant, Beijing-based, mainland, non-local, Shanghainese, Asian*
Reproduction	*biological*	*pregnant, reproductive, childbearing, maternal, second-child, eligible, child-bearing, prenatal, infertile, menstrual, contraceptive, gynecological, sanitary, folic, unborn, intrauterine, fertile, mother-to-child, maternity, caesarean, induced, tubal, obstetric, nine-month, ovarian, gynaecological, lactating, pregnancy-related, menopausal, childbearing-age*
Crimes/violence	*dead, sexual, injured, guilty, suspect, intentional, alleged, deadly, knife-wielding, unidentified, unnamed, tortured, wanted, hit-and-run, suspected*	*domestic, sexual, legal, physical, injured, abused, discriminatory, trafficked, battered*
Marital relation	*single, married, leftover, unmarried*	*single, married, unmarried, leftover, left-behind, marital, extramarital*,
Evaluative	*right*	*better, common, ideal, outstanding, remarkable*
Behaviour	*wild, unable, innocent, capable, feminine, ambitious, gentle, humble, masculine, upright, strongest, right-hand, effeminate, manly, stingy, brave*	*strong, independent, confident, feminine, capable, ambitious, conservative, obedient, unfaithful, chaste, subservient*
Intellect	*wise, well-educated*	*higher, educational, well-educated, illiterate, cleverer*
Appearance	*black, white, blind, naked, nude, muscular, paralyzed, bald, shirtless, half-naked, hairy, wrinkled, well-dressed, uniformed, bearded, tattered, bespectacled, grey-haired, peaked*	*modern, naked, fashionable, nude, clad, well-dressed, figure-hugging*
Attractiveness	*handsome, attractive, good-looking*	*beautiful, attractive, elegant, sexy, good-looking, desirable, prettier, erotic*
Occupation	/	*professional, executive, managerial*
Emotion	*angry, shy, jealous, troubled, nauseous*	*vulnerable, emotional, reluctant, jealous*
Patriarchy/tradition	*superior, inferior*	*male-dominated, inferior, superior*
Size	*tall, lanky, sturdy, diminutive, burly, obese, tallest, fattest*	*slender, petite*
Sexual orientation	*gay, homosexual, straight, bisexual, heterosexual*	/
HIV	*mobile, HIV-positive*	/
Lifestyle	*drunk, drunken*	/

women's clothing and style choices. This suggests a unique dynamic in Chinese media representation that differs from gender portrayal in American and European contexts.

Analysis of these co-occurring adjectives also reveals preferential gendered evaluation patterns in CD. MAN predominantly associates with physical descriptors across six main categories: Age, Appearance, Size (*tall*, *lanky*,

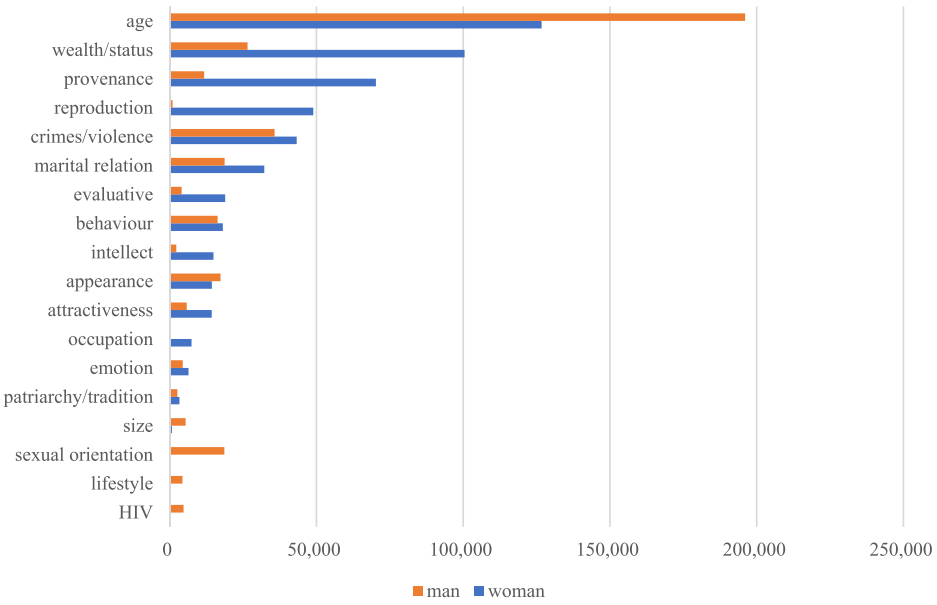


Fig. 8 Semantic categorization of top 200 adjectives co-occurring with MAN and WOMAN.

sturdy, *diminutive*, *burly*, *obese*), Sexual Orientation (*gay*, *homosexual*, *straight*, *bisexual*), Lifestyle (*drunk*, *drunken*), and health status (*HIV-positive*). Conversely, WOMAN's co-occurring adjectives span social and structural domains: Wealth/Status, Provenance (*local*, *rural*, *urban*), Reproduction (*pregnant*, *reproductive*, *childbearing*, *maternal*), Marital Relation, Evaluative (*better*, *common*, *ideal*, *outstanding*), Intellect (*higher*, *educational*, *well-educated*, *illiterate*), and Occupation. This distribution suggests a broad gendered contrast: men are more frequently characterized through physical attributes, while women are more frequently assessed through social and structural lenses. Notably, categories like Sexual orientation, HIV, and Lifestyle appear exclusively with MAN, while social descriptors show limited range for MAN but broader scope for WOMAN, such as Provenance, Reproduction, Evaluative, Intellect and Occupation. They suggest that women are more likely than men to be evaluated and judged based on their geographical background, occupation, intelligence, abilities, and reproductive status.

Despite the increasing participation of women in China's economic and political spheres, "the fundamental and traditionally accepted place of women in relation to the family, marriage, and sexuality has hardly changed" (Thakur, 1997, p. 189). Nevertheless, this study's findings present an interesting contrast to previous studies in other contexts. It contradicts with Caldas-Coulthard and Moon (2010)'s findings that "men are evaluated in terms of their function and status in society" and that "a woman is evaluated additionally in terms of their appearance and sexuality" (p. 124). Although Pearce (2008) notes that women are more frequently characterized by adjectives related to marital and reproductive status and sexual orientation compared to men, this study finds that while women show a preference for adjectives related to marital and reproductive status, men exhibit a stronger inclination toward adjectives concerning sexual orientation, particularly with terms like *gay* and *homosexual*.

Diachronic analysis of co-occurring adjectives of MAN and WOMAN

A diachronic analysis of those adjectives co-occurring with MAN and WOMAN may reveal significant shifts in binary gender representations across four periods. Figure 9 shows increasing prominence of such semantic categories as **Age, Reproduction, Occupation**, and **Marital relation**. This trend demonstrates a complex evolution in gender representation: while acknowledging women's professional identities and individual characteristics, media discourse simultaneously reinforces traditional gender roles centred on reproduction and marriage.

In contrast, several semantic categories demonstrate declining frequency, including **Wealth/Status, Provenance, Crimes/Violence, Patriarchy/Tradition**, and **Attractiveness**. This decrease suggests an evolution away from

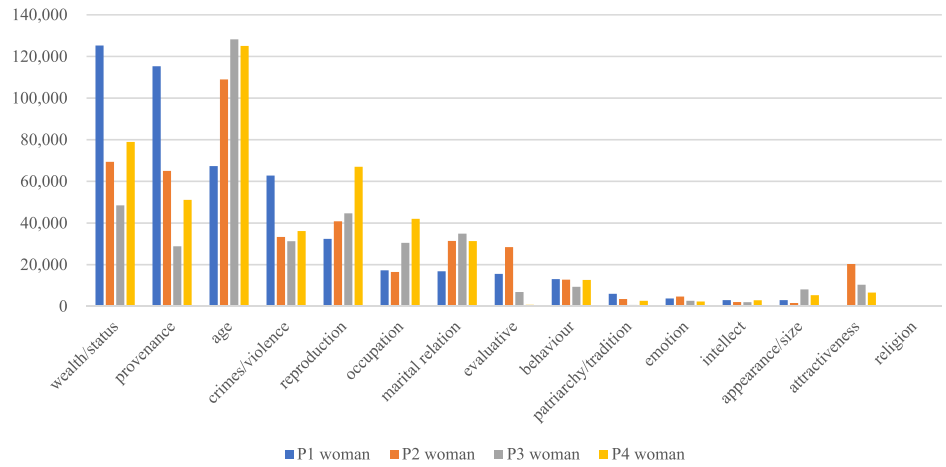


Fig. 9 Diachronic distribution of co-occurring adjectives of WOMAN.

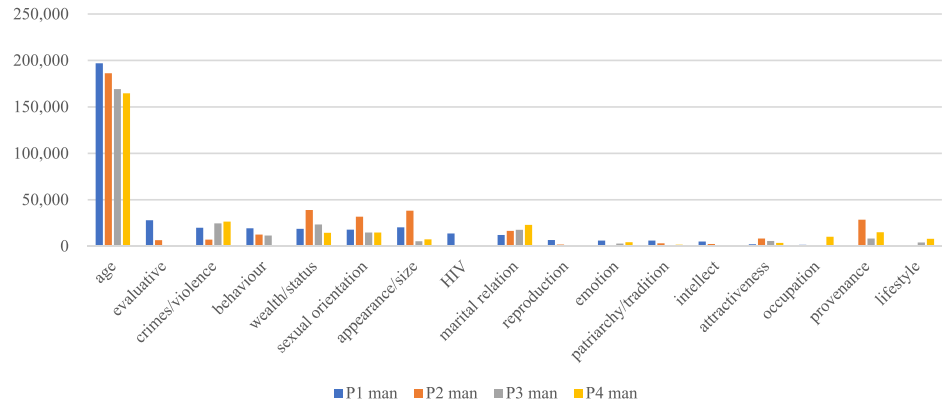


Fig. 10 Diachronic distribution of co-occurring adjectives of MAN.

historically discriminatory representations, particularly regarding socioeconomic status, regional identity, criminal involvement, traditional gender hierarchies, and appearance-based evaluation.

These diachronic shifts reflect a transforming media discourse that balances emerging recognition of women's professional and individual identities with persistent attention to traditional gender roles, while moving away from historically prejudiced representation patterns. The changes over four periods indicate both progress in gender representation and the endurance of certain traditional frameworks in CD.

Diachronic examination of MAN's co-occurring adjectives (Fig. 10), on the other hand, reveals significant changes in masculine representation across the studied periods. Multiple semantic categories show declining frequency, including **Age, Evaluative, Behaviour, Wealth/Status, HIV, Reproduction, Emotion, Patriarchy/Tradition, Intellect**, and **Provenance**, suggesting a gradual reduction in traditional male stereotypes in media discourse.

Conversely, categories related to **Crimes/Violence** and **Marital Relation** demonstrate increasing prominence, reflecting media's trend toward sensationalized news coverage and growing social attention to marriage and singlehood. Notably, period 2 is spotted with peak frequencies in **Wealth/Status, Sexual Orientation, Appearance**, and **Provenance** categories. The prominence of these categories in P2 can be attributed to the increasing influences of marketization as Chinese news media became increasingly market-driven after 2000, putting more emphasis on advertising, lifestyle content, and mass appeal (Winfield and Peng, 2005). However, the decline of these categories since P3 may be linked to the establishment of the Cyberspace Administration of China in 2014–2015, which marked a shift toward stricter regulation of online content and influenced how gender-related issues were presented.

These diachronic patterns suggest a complex evolution in men's representation, where traditional stereotypes generally decline while certain categories gain prominence, reflecting broader shifts in Chinese media practices and social attention. The changes further demonstrate the competing and dynamic influences of the market, the state, and feminism on binary gender representations.

Discussion and conclusion

The above examination of gender representations in CD reveals complex patterns influenced by competing social forces in contemporary China. Through systematic analysis of frequencies, co-occurrence networks, and co-occurring adjectives, this research identifies evident changes in how men and women are portrayed in Chinese media. The analytic processes include tracking changes in the usage of different gender terms (MAN, WOMAN, MALE, FEMALE), analysing associated topics and themes, and categorizing co-occurring adjectives into 18 semantic categories. This multi-dimensional analysis reveals both progressive patterns and persistent traditional elements in gender representations.

Though characterized by complexity and occasional contradiction, the findings indicate notable progress in women's representation from several aspects, suggesting the influence of feminist perspectives. The positive developments include a shift away from collective representation of women toward more individualized portrayals, increased attention to women's rights and health issues, and reduced emphasis on traditional status markers and provincial origins. Also, topics related to women have expanded to their professional achievements, educational advancement, and diverse life experiences across different age groups. This progress reflects increasing feminist awareness amid the changing social context of China.

Despite these advancements, traditional gender ideologies continue to persist in media representations (Attané, 2012; Evans, 2021). Our findings suggest that the media coverage places disproportionate emphasis on women's marital status and reproductive roles, frequently employing age-related descriptors and maintaining focus on domestic responsibilities. Besides, women are often framed as vulnerable or in need of protection while seldom represented in leadership and decision-making contexts. These stereotypical portrayals reflects the deeply-embedded social norms and expectations (Evans, 2021). The dynamic in media coverage of family relationships and professional achievements reveals a continuous tension between progressive perspectives and conventional social expectations (Feldshuh, 2018).

Market forces have also significantly shaped the content evolution in Chinese media (Chen, 2009). Since the 1990s the Chinese press has undergone significant reforms linked to marketization, in which state subsidies were reduced and news outlets were expected to become financially self-sufficient (He, 2000; Pan, 2000). Within this context, market pressures have encouraged greater emphasis on content that appeals to readers and advertisers. After 2000, Chinese media became increasingly market-driven, with more attention to advertising, lifestyle content, and popular appeal (Winfield and Peng, 2005). This environment coincides with the rise of consumerist masculinities that cantered on wealth, branded consumption, and fashionable appearance (Song and Hird, 2014). Our findings also suggest a growing focus of media content on appearance and physical attributes, with a tendency toward dramatic or controversial content such as sensational crimes and violence. This increasing salience of violent themes in the news can be related to the established news value of negativity (Harcup and O'Neill, 2001). Under market pressures, news outlets tend to highlight stories that are considered most valuable for attracting readers and generating profit. As such, influence from market may reinforce gender stereotypes while it also creates space for more diverse narratives and perspectives on gender-related issues.

State influence serves as another significant factor in shaping media content through various regulatory mechanisms and content guidelines (Lee, 2003). Government control is embedded in content restrictions, promotion of "positive energy' content, emphasis on traditional family values, and careful framing of sensitive social issues. The establishment of the Cyberspace Administration of China in 2014–2015 signalled a notable transformation toward stricter internet content regulation, particularly affecting how gender-related topics are presented. This development corresponds with the declining frequencies of the **Wealth/Status, Sexual Orientation**, and **Appearance** categories

in our diachronic analysis of the co-occurring adjectives of MAN. This regulatory framework aims to balance modernization with traditional values while maintaining social stability and cultural continuity.

Therefore, this study further verifies the competing and dynamic influences of state control, market forces, and feminism on binary gender representation in CD (Chen, 2009). Gender representations in CD continues to reflect the legacy of communist equality initiatives, the impact of economic liberalization, and the persistence of traditional family structures. The navigation through these forces results in selective emphasis and careful framing of gender-related representations in different ways. This study, however, is limited to the news reports in CD, which primarily targets international audiences. While this study offers valuable insights into how China represents traditional binary genders on a global stage, it may not fully reflect the perspectives found in Chinese-language media aimed at domestic readers. Similar methods can be adopted to examine the diachronic binary gender representations in other Chinese English-language news media (e.g., *Global Times* or *Women of China*) or Chinese-language media outlets (e.g., *People's Daily*) to present a more wholistic picture of gender representations in China's media system and a more comprehensive understanding of how the competing forces shape gender representations in different ways.

Looking forward, gender representations in Chinese media still confront critical challenges, which reside in the needs to balance traditional values with modern expectations and navigate between state control and market demands. The media must address generational differences in gender expectations while developing more sophisticated representation strategies. The role of feminism in this context remains constrained by the dominance of the state-market complex, necessitating strategic collaboration and focus on achievable incremental changes. Success in advancing gender equality in media representation will depend on the ability to effectively navigate these competing forces while maintaining cultural authenticity and social relevance.

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Data availability The corpus data are not publicly available due to copyright protection. However, readers with authorized access to *Factiva* may retrieve the original articles by applying these searching terms: *atleast2 women or atleast2 woman or atleast2 man or atleast2 men or atleast2 female or atleast2 females or atleast2 male or atleast2 males*. The URL for *Factiva* is: https://global.factiva.com.

Declarations

Competing interests The authors declare no competing interests.

Ethical approval The study does not involve human participants or their data.

Informed consent This article does not contain any studies with human participants performed by any of the authors.

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